

inworkable

ROB JENKINS ON THE RISE AND FALL OF WORLD
GOVERNMENT MOVEMENTS IN 1940S AMERICA



During the decade that I've taught a course on the Politics of Globalisation at Birkbeck, not a single student has written an essay on, or even seriously inquired about, 'world government' – the theoretical possibility of a global political authority exercising universal legal jurisdiction. Nor have students evinced interest in less drastic alternatives, such as what used to be called 'world federalism', in which nation-states would share power with a global body possessing limited powers of taxation, a standing military force, and sole control over nuclear weapons.

It's not just students that have abandoned the idea of world government. Once a staple of informed debate on international affairs, the term is almost never uttered in mainstream political discussion, unless to dismiss those who might advocate the idea as hopelessly naïve, or demonise those suspected of secretly plotting the creation of a global leviathan. The irony is that just when something like world government appears most feasible – due to advances in information and communication technology, and reduced barriers to the cross-border flow of goods, capital, people and ideas – it is considered beyond the realm of possibility. Though the US is accused of seeking global dominance, empire is not the same as world government. Indeed, the Bush administration's disdain for the United Nations reflects mainstream America's disdain for the idea of a rule-based form of world government.

And yet there was a time, during and just after the Second World War, when world government was very much on the US political agenda. It was the topic of a weekly lecture on the nationwide CBS radio network, of several best-selling books, and of resolutions passed by more than half of America's state legislatures. Popular enthusiasm for the idea outlasted even the creation of the United Nations in 1945. Far from satisfying world-government advocates, the UN (which possessed few powers independent of its member-states) merely whet their appetites.

My research in the United States, during a sabbatical from Birkbeck, has revealed to me the complexity as well as the strength of the globalist urge in America during what might be called 'the long 1940s' (late 1930s to early 1950s). I'm particularly interested in civic groups in America that took up the idea of world government with gusto during this period. Perhaps the first was the Campaign for World Government (CWG), founded by peace and women's rights

"THE IRONY IS THAT JUST WHEN
SOMETHING LIKE WORLD GOVERNMENT
APPEARS MOST FEASIBLE IT IS
CONSIDERED BEYOND THE REALM
OF POSSIBILITY"

A view of wax images of (from
top) Joseph Stalin, Chiang Kai
Shek, Winston Churchill and
President Franklin D. Roosevelt.
Getting world leaders together in
person proved more difficult.
(Time Life/Getty Images)

Rob Jenkins is Professor of
Political Science at Birkbeck's
School of Politics and Sociology,
and during 2005-06 is a fellow at
the Dorothy and Lewis B. Cullman
Center for Scholars and Writers at
the New York Public Library

activist Rosika Schwimmer in 1937. Combing through the CWG's archive in the New York Public Library, it's hard to decide whether the CWG represents the last gasp of the nineteenth-century tradition of amateur diplomacy or the forerunner of the social-justice-oriented, foreign-policy activism of the late twentieth century, which took the form of the anti-globalisation movement of the late 1990s.

Though it failed in the late 1930s to convince the Roosevelt administration to include the idea of world government in proposals to prevent the outbreak of another world war, the CWG raised the profile of the issue. But isolationism continued to dominate American foreign policy when the Senate refused to ratify the treaty creating the League of Nations.

In 1939, *New York Times* reporter Clarence Streit published the bestseller *Union Now*, arguing that it was pointless to await worldwide consensus on the need for such a body: the world's leading democracies could get the ball rolling by forming a federal union of democracies. He argued that this members of a democratic union would possess overwhelming military dominance, control over key natural resources, and preeminence in trade, industry, and finance. Unable to defeat the new union, the rest of the world's states would be forced to join it. To meet the membership criteria they would have to liberalise their political systems. There are obvious parallels with European Union enlargement, and indeed the complaints of today's Eurosceptics are reminiscent of those voiced by Streit's critics.

One of these was Rosika Schwimmer herself, who argued that a union of democracies would repel rather than attract the world's non-democracies. Universal membership was necessary for any international organisation to achieve its objectives. This argument was influential among mainstream groups that played a major role in formulating what became the United Nations. Foremost among these was the Commission to Study the Organisation of Peace, formed in 1939.

The shift of public opinion in favour of American participation in an international organisation during the 1940s owed a major debt to a Wendell Willkie, who ran unsuccessfully for president against FDR in 1940. His 1943 book *One World* urged America not to retreat back into isolationism and helped cure the Republican Party of knee-jerk isolationism.

Even before the UN charter was signed in 1945, the Cold War was already in the making. The prospect that it would heat up, and that the atomic bombs dropped on Japan might again be used, caused great anxiety among a huge cross-section of American society. Something much stronger than the UN was widely seen as necessary to avoid catastrophe. Schwimmer's plea for world government; Streit's call for an ever-closer global union; Willkie's articulation of one worldism – the legacy of this wartime activism was the emergence in 1947 of the centrist United World Federalists (UWF). Its bible was Emery Reves's *The Anatomy of Peace*, which argued that the UN model, built around nation-states, was insufficient to ensure peace. What was needed was worldwide law, applicable to a global citizenry.

This atmosphere of possibility helped the UWF draw support from Albert Einstein, Ronald Reagan and Broadway's Oscar Hammerstein and inspired the Student Federalists to become the largest non-partisan political organisation in the country.

It all ended rather suddenly. By the mid 1950s, the world government movement had ceased to be a political force. The Cold War came to dominate Americans' view of global politics, and Senator Joseph McCarthy's red-baiting cast world-government activists as part of a Soviet conspiracy to undermine American patriotism.

It's worth asking whether the idea of world government is as dead it might seem. The idea of the international criminal court, to which the US has not yet acceded, can be traced back to proposals by activists in the 1940s. But today's campaigners for global justice – the term anti-globalisation has gone out of favour – have no doubt learned from an earlier generation of American activists. They know that talk of world government (arguably the only means by which their objectives can be met) serves merely to antagonise powerful opponents. They may also have learnt from the European Union, which would likely have been still-born had people foreseen its evolution into the powerful institution it is today. A fragmented approach to reforming global governance might be the smart strategy for now, but a return to the idea of world government is not unthinkable in the not-too-distant future.

For information about degrees, certificates and diplomas in Politics at Birkbeck, call 0845 601 0174, email info@bbk.ac.uk or visit www.bbk.ac.uk/polsoc